How to Shop Safe Online & Avoid Payment Scams

THE GOLDEN RULE OF SHOPPING ONLINE:

If an offer seems **too good to be true**, it almost always is. Real sellers will never demand unusual payment methods or send extra money.

3 Big Red Flags to Watch Out For

1. Unrealistic Prices ("Too Good to Be True")

- **What it looks like:** A brand-new $500 laptop or smartphone listed online for only $35.
- **The Danger:** Scammers post fake photos of popular items at tiny prices to get your payment details.
- **What to do:** Compare prices on official store websites first. If a price is unbelievably cheap, walk away.

2. Risky Payment Demands

- **What it looks like:** A buyer or seller insists that you pay using gift cards (like Apple or Amazon cards), wire transfers (Western Union), or crypto.
- **The Danger:** Money sent this way is like cash—once you send it, **it cannot be recovered** if they disappear.
- **What to do:** Use a **credit card** for online stores (credit cards have fraud protection) or the official built-in checkout system on platforms like eBay or Facebook Marketplace.

3. The "Overpayment" Trap (For Sellers)

- **What it looks like:** You are selling an item for $50. A buyer sends you a check or payment for $200 "by accident" and asks you to send back the extra $150.
- **The Danger:** The buyer's check or payment is fake and will bounce in a few days—leaving you out $150 of your own money.
- **What to do: Never refund "accidental" extra money.** Tell your bank immediately if someone sends an unexpected check.

Safe Payment Method Guide

Payment Method	Safe for Online Shopping?	Why?
Credit Card	**YES (Safest)**	Your bank protects you if the item never arrives or is fraudulent.
Official Marketplace Checkout	**YES**	Platform guarantees (like eBay or Facebook Purchase Protection) keep your money safe.
Peer-to-Peer Apps (Zelle, Venmo)	**ONLY WITH PEOPLE YOU KNOW**	Treat these like physical cash or a check. Only use them with trusted friends or family.
Gift Cards / Wire Transfers	**NEVER**	Real businesses and legitimate buyers will **never** ask for gift cards as payment.

Safe Shopping Checklist

Keep these 3 quick rules in mind before hitting "Buy":

- Am I using a credit card or secure checkout system? → **Safe.**
- Is the seller asking me to leave the website to chat or pay somewhere else? → **Stop, it's likely a scam.**
- Did someone send me a check for more than my asking price? → **Do not deposit it.**